

Written-Response Comprehension — Answer Structures

WR

NAME	DATE	APPLIES TO	USE
Lupin	9 August 2026	Latymer · QE Boys' Barnet · Dame Alice Owen's	Every written-answer comprehension question

Your **Comprehension Operating System** sheet (7 August) covers how to eliminate distractor traps on multiple-choice comprehension — that's the right prep for **QE Boys' Barnet**, whose English paper is fully multiple-choice, GL Assessment format. This sheet is different: it's for **written-answer** comprehension, which is how **Latymer** (30 min reading + 30 min continuation-writing) and **Dame Alice Owen's** (a 1-hour paper: Section A comprehension, Section B creative writing) actually test reading. Checked against real specimen papers from both schools — every marks-in-brackets question below is modelled directly on their real question phrasing, not guessed.

THE ONE RULE THAT MATTERS MOST

MARKS-TO-POINTS

Before you write a single word, look at the marks in brackets. A question worth 3 marks needs three genuinely distinct points — not one good point said three different ways. A question worth 1 mark needs exactly one clear point, stated plainly, with no padding.

This is the single biggest source of dropped marks in written-response papers: strong readers who understand the passage perfectly but write a beautiful one-idea paragraph for a 4-mark question, and lose three marks they were fully capable of getting.

One real-paper wrinkle: the ratio isn't always exactly "1 mark = 1 point." Real Latymer and Dame Alice Owen's questions sometimes ask for several reasons/quotations but only award marks for the explanation, or split marks unevenly (e.g. 1 mark for spotting the right evidence, 2 more for explaining its effect). The marks in brackets are still the rule — just read exactly what they're attached to before assuming "3 marks" always means "list three things."

ANSWER TEMPLATES, BY QUESTION TYPE

1 · Retrieval / short factual

USUALLY 1 MARK · REAL EXAMPLES: "WHAT IS THE ONLY SOURCE OF LIGHT IN...", "GIVE A PIECE OF EVIDENCE THAT..."

State the fact. If the question says "in your own words," you must paraphrase — copying the exact phrase from the text scores zero even if it's the right fact.

[Fact], because/when [supporting detail from the passage, in your own words].

2 · "In your own words" / paraphrase

OFTEN JUST 1 MARK FOR A SINGLE REWORDED POINT — REAL EXAMPLE: "EXPLAIN IN YOUR OWN WORDS WHY..." (1 MARK). OCCASIONALLY MORE, IF THE QUESTION IS ASKING FOR SEVERAL POINTS.

The no-lifting rule: you cannot reuse three or more consecutive words from the original text and still score that point. Swap the key words for genuine synonyms — don't just rearrange the same words into a different order, that's still lifting.

Original: "she hesitated, unwilling to admit the mistake" → Your words: "she paused, reluctant to own up to what she'd got wrong"

3 · Explain / Why

USUALLY 1 MARK FOR A SINGLE WELL-EVIDENCED POINT, UP TO 3 IF THE QUESTION ASKS FOR MORE THAN ONE REASON

Never just quote and stop — a quotation with no explanation attached scores the evidence mark at most, not the explain mark.

Point: [your point] — **Evidence:** "[short embedded quotation]" — **Explain:** this shows/suggests [why it proves your point].

4 · Language / effect analysis

USUALLY 2–4 MARKS · COMMONLY SPLIT 1 MARK FOR IDENTIFYING THE RIGHT EVIDENCE + 2 FOR EXPLAINING ITS EFFECT

Naming a technique ("the writer uses a metaphor") is worth almost nothing on its own. The marks are in explaining what the specific word choice does to the reader.

The writer's use of "[word/phrase]" suggests [connotation/image], which creates an impression of [effect] and makes the reader feel/picture [reader response].

WATCH FOR: don't drift into retelling the plot — every sentence in a language-effect answer should be doing analytical work, not summary.

5 · Structure / organisation

USUALLY 3–4 MARKS · ORDER-OF-REVEAL, THEN ITS EFFECT

Track what information the writer gives the reader first, second, third — and why that order was chosen rather than a different one.

The writer withholds/reveals [detail] until [point in the extract]. This has the effect of [suspense/sympathy/surprise/dramatic irony] because the reader [what the reader now knows or feels that they didn't before].

6 · Character / "what do we learn about X"

USUALLY 3–4 MARKS · REAL EXAMPLE: "GIVE 3 QUOTATIONS... EXPLAIN WHAT YOUR CHOICE REVEALS" (3 MARKS — ROUGHLY 1 PER QUOTATION, BRIEFLY EXPLAINED)

Treat this as several mini-answers, not one long paragraph. Each point needs its own piece of evidence — reusing the same quotation for two "different" points only scores once. Because the mark-per-point here is smaller than a full language-effect answer, keep each explanation to a sentence, not a paragraph.

Firstly, [character trait] — shown when "[quote]," which suggests [brief explain]. In addition, [second, genuinely different trait] — shown when "[quote]," which suggests [brief explain].

7 · Summary

USUALLY 4–6 MARKS WHERE IT APPEARS · ONE MARK PER DISTINCT, CORRECT POINT COVERED

Coverage beats elegance. List the separate events/ideas in your own words; order roughly follows the passage but doesn't have to be exact. Don't repeat a point using different phrasing — the examiner is counting distinct ideas, not sentences. (Neither of the two specimen papers checked for this sheet happened to include a pure summary question, but it's a standard 11+ written-response type worth having ready.)

[Point 1, own words]. [Point 2, own words — must be a genuinely new idea, not a restatement of point 1]. [Point 3, own words]...

SENTENCE STARTERS — MEMORISE A HANDFUL

USE FOR	STARTER
Introducing evidence	"This is shown when the writer states..." / "This is reinforced by..."
Explaining effect	"This suggests to the reader that..." / "This creates an impression of..."
Adding a second point	"In addition..." / "Furthermore..." / "This is also seen when..."
Contrasting	"In contrast..." / "However, this changes when..."
Cause and result	"As a result..." / "This leads to..." / "Because of this..."

TIME BUDGET — WRITTEN-ANSWER PAPER

First read of the whole passage, no writing yet

≈ 3 min

Rule of thumb per question

≈ 1 min per mark

A 4-mark question

≈ 4 min, four visible points

Final sweep — check every mark-count is actually met

last 3–4 min

WORKED EXAMPLE

"Mia had checked the running order twice already, but she checked it a third time anyway, because the alternative was sitting still with the thought that kept circling back: the jingle file on the desk wasn't the one she remembered exporting."

Why did Mia check the running order a third time? (2 marks)

- ✓ **Point 1 (1 mark):** She had a nagging worry/doubt about the jingle file — "the thought that kept circling back."
- ✓ **Point 2 (1 mark):** Checking again was a way of avoiding sitting with that worry — "the alternative was sitting still with the thought."

What does "circling back" suggest about Mia's state of mind? (2 marks)

- ✓ **Technique/quote (1 mark):** "circling back" suggests something repetitive, going round and round, like a thought she can't switch off.
- ✓ **Effect (1 mark):** this creates an impression of mounting anxiety rather than a single passing doubt, making the reader sense her unease is building, not settled.